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# TRANSCENDENCE

FOR THE DIGITAL ANTHROPOCENE

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Ideas for Art for the post human age.

# Curation thesis in brief

## Art is Transcendence

Historically, art has always been an experience of a beyond the 'everyday self' (i.e. transcendence)

Transcendence is dependent on the essence of man being beyond the mechanical and beyond nature. However, the terms man, nature, machine have changed with Darwinism, the discovery of DNA, climate change, and machine learning.

## Transcendence has to be redefined

Our definition of transcendence has to change

## The experience of Transcendence is mysterium tremendum (terrorizes) fascinans (attracts)

In religious studies, one of the most influential descriptions of transcendence (Otto) has been of a mystery that is both terrorizing and at the same time, fascinating.

## Transcendence for the future has to be based on these four changes in the way we see ourselves

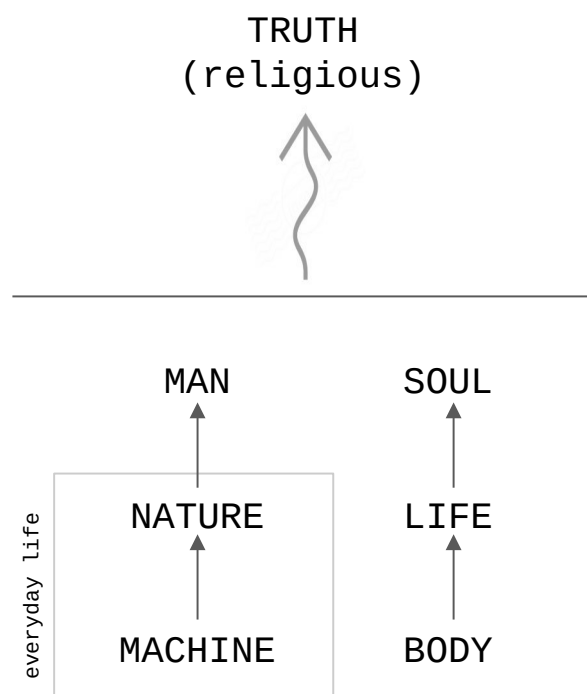
1. We think of man as a machine
2. Machines are becoming behaviorally indistinguishable from humans
3. Mind - Body distinction has been problematized -- man is seen as purely biological
4. Nature is gaining personhood

## Art that evokes these new forms of transcendence is art that is relevant for the future

# A new Theory on The Future of Art

The future of art is the future of the of transcendence  
Historically, art has always been an experience of a beyond the 'everyday self'.

Transcendence has been dependent on the essence of man being beyond the mechanical and beyond nature.



*Fig 1.0 Traditional ideas of transcendence*

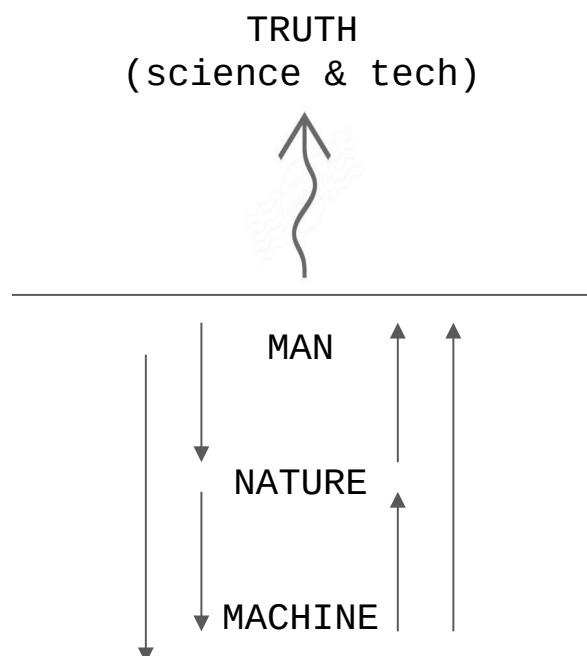
# Our definition of transcendence has to change

The first phase of changes in the traditional model involved systematically demoting man and nature to machine

With Newton Reducing Nature to Machine, Darwinism reducing Man to Nature and the discovery of DNA reducing Man to Machine. This led to art movements like the romantic movement, expressionism, dada, futurism and finally Marcel Duchamp's aesthetics of recontextualization and its descendants.

The second phase involves promoting machine and nature to man

Consciousness of climate change, complexity of economies led to Nature/ System being thought of as the new locus of responsibility and agency. Machines have become our natural environment with the rise of the internet. With the rise of machine learning and artificial intelligence, machines are poised to replace and even outdo man in all spheres of activity.



*Fig 2.0 Changing conception of self*

| Category                | 1                      | 2                                                       | 3                             | 4                                                     | 5                                              | 6                             |
|-------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Breakthrough            | Newton                 | Darwin                                                  | DNA / Computing               | Environment movement                                  | Internet                                       | Machine Learning              |
| Date                    | 1670                   | 1850                                                    | 1940's                        | 1960's-70's                                           | 1990's                                         | 2000's                        |
|                         | Nature ← Machine       | Man ← Nature                                            | Man ← Machine                 | Nature ← Man                                          | Machine ← Nature                               | Machine ← Man                 |
| Terronising aspect      | Horror of Chance       | Loss of Interpersonal and Personal Reality              | Loss of Agency                | Apocalyptic Scenarios                                 | Loss Of Instinct /Immediacy /Direct Connection | Loss Of Validation            |
|                         | Death of Active God    | Fear of Anarchy with the rise of Opportunistic Behavior | Loss of Free Will             | Loss Of Control Over Consequences (Lost Of Lt Vision) | Filter Bubble -- Fads                          | Decline Into Insignificance   |
|                         |                        |                                                         | Nihilism                      |                                                       |                                                | (Intelligence/Consciousness)  |
| Fascinating aspect      | Manipulation of Nature | Bio Hackability of The Human                            | Liberation From Emotions      | Liberation From Imagination                           | Liberation From Environment                    | Liberation From Labor         |
|                         |                        | Liberation from The Body                                |                               | Liberation From Individual Judgement                  |                                                |                               |
| Cultural Manifestations | Hormone Fed Cattle     | Drugs/Sex/Music                                         | Behavioral Psychology         | Pollution, Climate Change                             | Fake News (Internet)                           | AI, Recommendation Algorithms |
|                         | Seed Manipulation      | Yoga / Reiki                                            | Randomized Experiments        | Chaos Theory                                          | Bofriends                                      | Distributed Intelligence      |
|                         | Industrial Revolution  | Faith Healing                                           | Ab Testing                    | Apocalypse Movies                                     | Mmmpg / Second Life                            | Robots                        |
|                         | Nature → Imagination   |                                                         | Nihilism                      | Stuffed Toys Of Endangered Animals, Bunkers           | Ipad Addiction . Virtual Replacing Reality     | Turing Test                   |
|                         |                        |                                                         |                               | Environmental Movements 60S And 70S                   |                                                |                               |
| Art                     |                        | Dna Art                                                 | Remote Controlled Cockroaches | Collective Art / Patronage                            | Robotic Pets -- Virtual Lovers                 | AI Painters                   |
|                         |                        | Unoriginal Art                                          | Cyborgification               | New Models Of Learning / Edu                          |                                                | AI Authors                    |
|                         |                        | Designer Drugs/ Viruses                                 | Neural Art                    | Different Forms Of Personhood / Nation                |                                                |                               |
|                         |                        | Bio Hacks                                               |                               |                                                       |                                                |                               |
|                         |                        | Movement Art                                            |                               |                                                       |                                                |                               |

Fig 3.0 Table of changing concepts of self and their cultural and artistic ramifications